provides three PCI slots, and the best part is that all of them are very useable even after installing a display card.

MSI provides a healthy CPU overclock from 200 MHz default to 425 MHz, in 0.5 MHz increments. All the usual HT, memory and PCI-Express tweaks are present in full force, and we can safely recommend this board to all but the most hardcore of overclockers.

Comparing the layout of theses two boards, we decided the K9N SLI Platinum zooms ahead.

There was another motherboard from MSI—the MSI K9NU Neo V, which, due to its price, falls in a slot below the other MSIs available. It's also based around a non-SLI/CrossFire chipset, and was just what we needed... a bit of the sedate, the mundane, after all the scorchers before it!

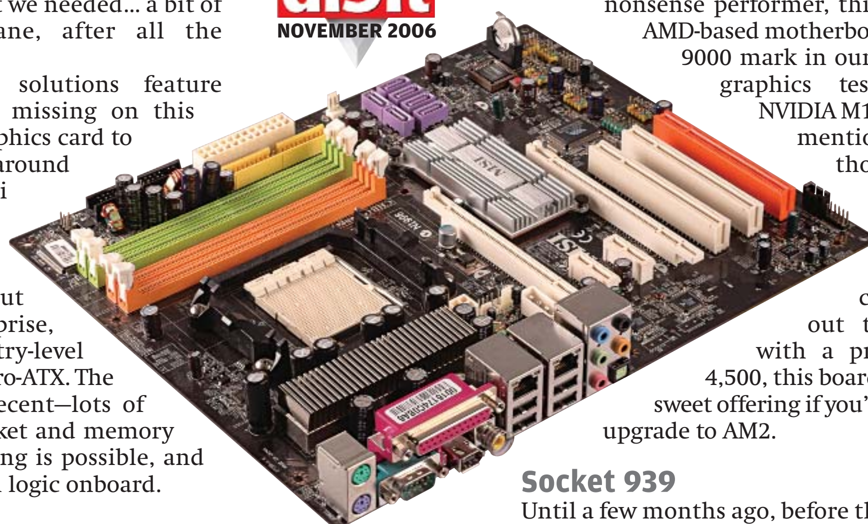
Typically, entry-level solutions feature onboard video, which is missing on this board, so you'll need a graphics card to set it up. The Neo V is built around NVIDIA's M1697 chipset (ALi 1697, as it was known before NVIDIA's takeover). The Neo V is no larger than any of the other boards, but is still somewhat of a surprise, because we're used to entry-level solutions being mostly Micro-ATX. The layout of the Neo V is decent—lots of space around the CPU socket and memory region. A bit of overclocking is possible, and this board has the core cell logic onboard.

Performance

We found pretty even scores among the AM2 boards, and even more surprising was the fact that the nForce 570SLI boards were at times neck and neck with the higher-end 590SLI based boards. This goes to show that the 590SLI is only better for those who just have to have a top-end board, or are planning on SLI-ing two high-end cards (say two 7900GTs and above). With a single graphics card under the hood, things remain interesting, and it's impossible to discern which chipset is which by looking at the scores. We also noted that both the Gigabyte boards lag behind the contenders from MSI and ASUS.

If you'll take a peek at our table, you'll see one board that's pretty consistent across all tests, and emerges with quite a few top scores—the feature loaded and attractive Crosshair from ASUS. With great performance, immense overclocking potential, reasonable future proofing and looks to die for, the Crosshair emerges a winner, we're giving it Gold—our *Digit Best Buy Gold* award. The *Best Buy Silver* goes to the MSI K9N Platinum (an nForce 570SLI based board). A well laid out, no-nonsense performer, this was the only AMD-based motherboard to cross the 9000 mark in our PC Mark 2005 graphics test suite. The NVIDIA M1697 also merits mention here—though not amongst the award winners, it kept pretty close throughout the tests, and with a price tag of Rs 4,500, this board makes quite a sweet offering if you're planning the upgrade to AM2.

BEST BUY digit NOVEMBER 2006



MSI K9N SLI Platinum
Great Performance and SLI support on a budget

Socket 939

Until a few months ago, before the Core 2 Duos, AMD was sitting pretty with their Athlon 64 processors, and had torn Intel's offerings to bits. However, Socket 939 is no longer a high-end or really sought-after platform.

The main reason for Socket 939's demise is the industry-wide shift to DDR2 memory. While the reasons for the shift and the causes for AMD's adoption of the same aren't in this article's purview, it's worth noting that DDR memory is no longer a manufacturing priority, and stocks should dry up over the next year.

At the very outset, Socket 939 doesn't make a very future-proof buy, simply because both processors and memory for the platform will not be available after a while (we give Socket 939 another eight months tops)!

The only scenario that would garner votes for a socket 939-based system in our opinion is if you are on an unshakeable low budget, or simply want a cheap PC which you do not plan to upgrade—a new user making his first foray into the world of personal computing. Socket 939 makes a decent buy for extremely value conscious users, as they get decent performance on a shoestring budget, sacrificing, of course, on the other fronts we mentioned.

Features

The Xpress 3200 chipset was a latecomer for socket 939, and was intended as ATI's counter to the nForce 4 SLI32 chipset that NVIDIA had released at the time. The Xpress 1600 differs only in the number of PCI-Express lanes it offers, that is, 16 as opposed to 32 for the Xpress

benchmark, SiSoft runs individual, modular tests for each subsystem, that is, memory, processing, storage, etc., and the results are obtained from each benchmark.

3D Mark 2005: The gamers' benchmark from Future Mark Corp., the people behind the PC Mark series. We used 3D Mark 2005 instead of 3D Mark 2006 because the latter is more graphics-heavy and less dependant on other subsystems, and we wanted to notice some disparity in the tests, since the subjects were motherboards and not graphics cards.

Our real-world tests included a video encoding test. We used a test file (100 MB VOB), and encoded it to DivX using the default settings. We used version 6.2 of DivX Encoder. This is primarily a CPU subsystem test.

Our next benchmark saw us loading the first level—"Training"—of *Far Cry*, and noting down the time taken to load the game. We used a fresh installed copy each time, and used version 1.32 of the game. This test stresses the hard drive, that is, the storage subsystem.

Finally, we used Doom 3's inbuilt time demo and recorded the frames per second that each card gave us. The first scores were disregarded, and an average of the next three scores was taken as our final figure. This gives us a good idea of what the video subsystem is capable of.